

Writing Seminar: Arranging Argument

You have spent some time thinking about how to arrange **claims**, **grounds**, and **warrants** in relation to one another. These terms allow us to construe a wide range of arguments using a single, accessible model. This model does not capture all of the subtleties and complexities of writing, but it does provide one means for asking how local arguments hold together (or don't!).

Generally speaking, when you write argumentative paragraphs for academic papers, you want each paragraph to contain **one single** persuasive-yet-contestable claim. This claim should answer the question: “what’s the **point** of this paragraph?” And that underlying point should be supported by one or more grounds – or pieces of evidence. In your case, such evidence will be textual: you will cite, paraphrase, and summarize from a text you read in class.

An argumentative paragraph, in this view, should at very least contain a prominent claim and clear evidence. It should also explain how the claim and evidence are related, in this way describing the underlying reasoning at work (what we’ve been calling a warrant).

Until now, we have talked about the *components* of argument, but we have not talked about their *arrangement*. One important question we need to ask is: where in a given paragraph should claims, grounds, and warrants go? What do you say first? What do you say last? And what do you say in between? Most importantly: how can you most effectively place the **main point**?

EXAMPLE #1: Non-academic point-last

Here’s an amusing example from a finance blogger I follow, mostly because he often says funny things about markets, NFTs, and dumb corporations destroying the world:

Investment banking is a business of building long-term relationships. Your job, as an investment banker, is to become close to the people who possess giant piles of money, in the hopes that one day they will do giant deals with their giant piles of money and give you some of it. If you are at the weekly meeting of an investment-banking group and everyone is going around the room talking about what they did last week, and someone says “I did a billion-dollar merger and earned an \$8 million fee for the bank,” and you say “I played Settlers of Catan with Mark Zuckerberg,” *you win*, because the expected value of proximity to a giant pile of money is so much higher than the value of an actual fee from a normal-sized pile of money. (Matt Levine, *Money Stuff*, 20 September 2021)

We can dissect this paragraph using the model we discussed last time. I have highlighted the **main point** in **yellow**, the **grounds** in **green**, and any **stated warrants** in **purple**:

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pile of money is so much higher than the value of an actual fee from a normal-sized pile of money. (Matt Levine, *Money Stuff*, 20 September 2021)

We'll notice a few things about this paragraph, which is decidedly Not Academic.

First, Levine opens with explanatory material that inform his reasoning. His argument relies upon the assumption that you will not contest his characterization of investment banking as (a) depending on long-term relationships for (b) the acquisition of fiat currency. And he tells you so! You will not be surprised to learn that this is also the first paragraph of the newsletter: the same assumptions will inform many paragraphs to follow.

Second, Levine frames his **main point** in terms of mathematics (or game-theory). In fact, in a sense, he does not ever state the true point of the essay: that being close to a giant pile of money is *better* than actually having a normal-sized pile of money. (Let's leave aside that \$8,000,000 is not, for most humans, a "normal-sized" pile of money.) Rather, he says that the *expected value* is higher.

Third, this means we also have an important *unstated warrant* hiding among all of this admirable clarity, namely: "having higher expected gain in fiat currency is better than having a lower expected gain in fiat currency." He makes a quantitative statement, and we are supposed to make the jump to the qualitative statement: winning is better, and winning means *expecting* to have more stuff, not just *having more stuff*. (The logic is reminiscent of Socrates' take on desire, come to think).

Fourth, Levine uses a hypothetical situation as his grounds. In this context, you would want to use a scene or citation from a relevant course-text. But Levine doesn't have a course-text! So he invents a bit of fiction to support his point. The nice thing about what you've been asked to do is that you don't have to invent your own stories.

Above all we should notice that this is a classic example of an author saving the **main point** for last, making it the final thing the paragraph says. This is especially common in informal writing, but the technique can be used effectively in formal writing as well.

EXAMPLE #2: Academic Point-First

Here's an academic article comparing the treatment of burial rites in two texts from our readings this quarter: Homer's *Iliad* and Sophocles' *Antigone*:

Achilles goes beyond the bounds of acceptable behavior in a different way. In Homer's text, heroes boast that they will allow the body of the vanquished to lie unburied and be eaten by wild birds and dogs; the boast somehow even adds to the *kleos*, or glory, of the victor. As is often pointed out, one key difference between the classical period and Homer's text is the classical institution of *anairesis*, whereby after a battle a truce was granted by the victors to enable the defeated to recover the bodies of their dead for burial. The classic case of the disastrous consequences of failing to bury one's own dead is the events of 405, when the Athenians won a naval battle at Arginusae but neglected to collect the bodies of some of their men. The generals in charge were put on trial and executed.

Again, I have highlighted the **main point** in **yellow**, the **grounds** in **green**, and any **stated warrants** in **purple**:

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This is a bit of an exaggerated example, but I want to be clear that have not changed it at all. And it is not atypical of a certain mode of academic writing associated with some humanities disciplines – such as linguistics or history. The author has a point: what Achilles does is not normal! **The author places that point first.**

And he has evidence: all of these other things are normal or acceptable (with some differences). In this case, we also have at least one unstated warrant. One such warrant might run something like “when everyone treats the dead one way and one person treats the dead another way that is different and also bad, that one person's behavior is not acceptable.” But you could think of others.

You can see why the author might not want to write the warrant I devised. In your writing, I would encourage you to give some further explanation linking your claim to your evidence: in this published case, the article continues to discuss Achilles' behavior in these terms. The implied warrant – “this is how bodies were usually treated, which was good” – informs the rest of the paper.

EXAMPLE #3: Academic Point-Last

Enough about money and bodies. Let's talk about STYLE. Here is a paragraph from Robert Alter's introduction to his translation of *Genesis*, another course text for HBC. Alter writes:

The assumption of biblical philologists that parallel syntax is alien to modern literary English is belied by the persistent presence of highly wrought paratactic prose even at the end of the twentieth-century. A variety of self-conscious English stylists in the modern era, from Gertrude Stein to Cormac McCarthy, have exhibited a fondness for chains of parallel utterances linked by “and” in which the basic sentence-type is the same structurally as that used again and again in biblical prose. What such a style makes manifest in a narrative is a series of more or less discrete events, or micro-events, in a chain, not unlike the biblical names of begetters and begotten that are strung one after another in the chains of the genealogical lists. The continuing appeal, moreover, for writers in our own age of this syntax dominated by “and,” which highlights the discrete event, suggests that parallel syntax may still be a perfectly viable way to represent in English the studied parallelism of verbs and clauses of ancient Hebrew narrative.

Parataxis! As ever, **main point** in yellow, **grounds** in green, any **stated warrants** in purple:

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Most of this will feel fairly familiar! As grounds, Alter appeals to the habits of successful modern writers in English. His main point is that a syntax dominated by “and” is a viable way of translating parallel structures in Hebrew. And his warrant explains how it is that such a style works, in both linguistic contexts. Note that the point, again, falls at the paragraph’s end.

We might also note an underlying, hidden warrant here: that being like successful English stylists (e.g. Stein or McCarthy) characterizes a viable strategy for Alter himself, and so translators in general. We might ask: why leave this warrant (or something like it) unstated?

But I’m sure you are wondering – “Tom! What about that first sentence!? You didn’t highlight it at all!” It’s a fair question with an unfair answer, and I am going to ask you about it at the beginning of our next seminar meeting. What *is* that sentence doing there?

ASSIGNMENT:

Your assignment for this week has three parts:

1. **Before completing part 3.** Read this informational sheet, or watch the corresponding video lecture, or both.
2. **No later than 48hrs before your seminar meeting.**
 - a. Locate your Canvas Group and its corresponding Google Document for this meeting.
 - b. Upload a draft of your second paper to the Google Document.
 - i. This draft does not have to be perfect! We will discuss whatever you are able to bring!
 - ii. But we cannot discuss what does not exist.
 - iii. In times of great need, focus on *argumentative paragraphs* – what some of you might be inclined to call “body paragraphs.”
 1. Do not fret endlessly over your introduction or your conclusion for the purposes of writing seminar.
3. **Before your seminar meeting begins.**
 - a. Skim the materials that your peers have submitted.
 - b. Respond to the draft for which you have been designated lead respondent.
 - i. First, read the draft in full,
 - ii. Then, choose *two argumentative paragraphs*: one that you found especially persuasive and one that you found in need of improvement.
 1. Identify the main **claim** of the paragraph, and highlight the sentence that captures that claim most clearly in **yellow**.
 2. Identify any **grounds** used to support that claim, and highlight sentence(s) that serve as grounds in **green**.
 3. Using Toulmin’s method, write a warrant that directly connects **one** grounds provided to the claim.
 4. In your estimation, do the grounds provided effectively support what you understand to be the main claim of the paragraph? Why or why not?
 5. Write a brief note to your peer – you may be direct, but please also be kind.